Chapter 15: Want Power. Make Deals.

Slayde and Bruis walked into the Spotted Lion, a tavern in Alfir and walked up to the counter.

The part clurichaun behind it didn't need to ask who they were or what they wanted, but simply told them, "Second room on the right." He then proceeded to pour drinks for them.

"I don't trust you," Slayde retorted. "I know never to drink anything given to me by a faeborn. Your punch will likely make me sing."

"Or worse, tell the truth," Bruis muttered.

The part clurichaun put the mugs down and urged, "Go. They are waiting."

They? Slayde was only expecting one person.

Yet, he and Bruis walked confidently into the second room on the right. Two men were there. One was Aiden, the invincible. He was expected. The other was Quex, the unstoppable.

“Can we trust him?” Slayde grunted, pointing to Quex. “He is fairly new to your team.”

“He shares our goal,” Aiden responded. “Please, have a seat.” He motioned to chairs across a table he and Quex were sitting at.

Slayde and Bruis sat down and Slayde explained, “We’ve had setbacks. Obviously, we won Bruis’s return, but the new war mage from Cruia is good.” He looked around, leaned over the table slightly, and whispered, “Calix and Lysander have reported that Erik and Catria are to be married. The believe he is moving to Terrian and joining their team.”

“He can’t,” Aiden corrected. “Their team is full.”

Slayde laughed. “Your reconnaissance is not that good. There is rumor of Rhys retiring or joining Cruia’s warmage team.”

Quex hit his hand on the table. “We must stop them. Erik and Catria together could be strong. We need to challenge them to battle and have an accident.” He smiled. “Perhaps it doesn’t need to be accidental. If they are suspected of something bad enough, we can challenge them to the death. York is very willing to have blood drawn in the arena. After all, it makes for more battles, and if the war ends, he has no power.”

“But I want the war ended,” Aiden insisted. “I want it ended with Aschelle ruling all the cities.”

“All but ours,” Slayde corrected. “You have promised that if we help with the thefts and framing other cities

that you will not rule Phyrn, but will unite all the tribes under me, with the warmage team being in charge."

"Of course," Aiden conceded. "I do not with to rule Phyrn. You were already stealing to gain money and power, but you are aiding me by framing other cities. I will unite all the tribes with you in charge when Aschelle gets control of the cities."

He poured some wine in goblets and offered them to Aiden and Quex, assuring them, "This is not fairy wine. I brought it from Aschelle." He then motioned to the mugs and offered, "Choose one."

Given that Aiden wasn't handing him one, Slayde trusted they weren't poisoned, so he took one, so did Bruis. They still clicked their goblets together to mix the drinks to make sure.

As they all drank, Slayde asked, "Were you able to get York to agree to let you attack to take over Terrian?"

"Not yet," Aiden answered. "He is not eager to have the war end, as he'll lose power. Yet, I think with Erik and Catria, he might see reason." He thought for a moment and asked, "When are they getting married?"

"I'm not sure," Slayde answered. "In Phryn, if we want to get married, we catch are girl and marry immediately, but Terrian has traditions and betrothals."

"We do too," Aiden pointed out. "It is civil and proper."

"In your culture," Bruis corrected. "What's civil and

proper is not absolute."

"Indeed," Aiden agreed. "In our culture, we don't fantasize about love. We marry for practicality."

"Indeed," Quex confirmed. "I am courting Freya. We both are from noble houses, and it will keep our children's blood pure and give us both more prestige if we marry."

Bruis shrugged. "How I see it, a woman is a woman. They're all pretty much the same except in appearance, and if they aren't, they can be beaten into submission."

Aiden didn't correct him, but surprisingly Slayde did.

"All women aren't the same. Xena is beautiful and a great cook. I will have her. We must get her back."

Aiden laughed. "Good luck. Cruia doesn't lose."

"They won't be as tough without Erik," Slayde mocked. "We can beat them. We got Bruis back, didn't we?"

"Against Terrian, not Cruia," Quex pointed out. "Perhaps we need to fight to get Xena for you. Aschelle can beat any team." He thought for a moment and corrected, "But that would look bad for us. We cannot let anyone know you are working for us."

"With you," Slayde corrected. "I will rule over all the tribes of Phyrn."

"And Aschelle will rule over all the cities," Quex added. His eyes met Slaydes. "Except Phyrn, of course."

Aiden drank from his goblet and almost slammed it on the table. “I don’t care about Xena. She is of no concern to me. I care about Aschelle getting power. We should rule all the cities. Now, if you want the power I can give you, then you need to do more. I want Erik and Catria framed for something huge, something big enough that we can challenge them to the death. York will allow that.”

Slayde smiled. “You want something big. We can deliver. We’ll get reason to charge them, and you two can kill them in the arena.”

Quex nodded. “I’m looking forward to it.”